

CAD FORUM

GREAT COACHES MAKING GREAT DEBATERS

Ben Voth, *Southern Methodist University*

The Civil Rights era of the 1960s represents one of the more profound periods of political struggle and success in American history. The cultural dominance of Jim Crow laws was repudiated by federal legislation guaranteeing voting rights and enshrining a substantial measure of a dream articulated by one of the great leaders of that day who gave his life for the cause-- Martin Luther King. Integral to the progress made at that time was the steady use of argument and debate on behalf of African Americans.

Near the center of this profound rhetorical moment certainly stands an activist by the name of James Farmer Jr. His work in founding the Congress of Racial Equality with his associated activism in the South was a central impetus to the success of the civil rights struggle (Bell 2009). While King was sharing his dream in DC, it was Farmer who sat in the all too common jail cell reserved for activists like him and MLK. Farmer's work and arguments certainly make him worthy of the title, "Great Debater."

In 2007, Hollywood helped the world better understand how James Farmer Jr. was shaped and molded into the

American leader he became by the passions of a debate coach--Melvin Tolson--and the considered processes of competitive college debate. The film starring Denzel Washington as coach Melvin Tolson focused on the relationship of Tolson to his 1935 debate squad that would go on to defeat the national champions in a public debate. The film transposed Harvard for the historically accurate USC team but stayed true to the general sense of struggle inherent when black schools like Wiley College attempted to debate with, in the era, white schools.

The film is an important contemporary catalyst for understanding the socially transformative power of debate. This issue of CAD is dedicated to an extension of that spirit but considering the task of "Making Great Debaters." In the assembly of this special issue, the matter has become infused with its own unique sense of history. In 2009, the college debate community mourned the loss of two of its 'great debate coaches'-- Ross Smith and Scott Deatherage. Smith, the coach of Wake Forest and Deatherage the coach of Northwestern had won numerous national championships. Toward the end of their too brief careers, they matured their coaching and administrative talents to the broader social task of making great debaters. Both men became substantially immersed in stepping beyond the small circle of elite competitive success and into the broader public concern of how great debaters are made and how this process betters our own society. Whether stirring urban debate leagues across the nation or more inclusive public debate formats in DC, Chicago, and North Carolina, both coaches, after winning national titles, made decisive contributions to the betterment of society.

In an effort to further the dreams of Tolson, Deatherage, Smith, the new college debate programs of SMU and Wiley College collaborated to begin anew the processes of making great debaters. The movie *The Great Debaters* mentioned an invitation from SMU to come and debate in 1935. Such a debate would have been among the first between a predominantly

white college and an all black college like Wiley. Unfortunately, the debate never took place.

Upon the initiation of the two programs, as the director of SMU's new program, I contacted the director at Wiley, Shannon Labove. We took steps to complete the invitation made in 1935. In January of 2009, SMU debaters traveled to the Wiley campus in Marshall, Texas for a debate. The debate took place mere days after the nation inaugurated its first African American president. The debate resolution for the evening's debate: Resolved: that a good leader believes that the pen is mightier than the sword. Wiley took the affirmative and SMU took the negative. In an auditorium brimming with student body, alumni, supporters and media, there was a palatable energy to the event. The debate was the first debate on Wiley's campus in more than 80 years (Bushong 2009). It was the first debate in the school's history with a majority served college. The debate was a spirited exchange on the competing virtues of diplomacy and war. Utilizing the parliamentary style, the debate featured regular audience participation in the form of hands banging on the armrests when they agreed with an advocated point. It was the best debate my debaters ever lost as we transcended history, culture, and racial barriers to demonstrate the powerful civic values that Farmer and Tolson thought could change the world. The mood on campus at Wiley was euphoric as they witnessed the rebirth and victory of their debate program after so many years of its absence.

Wiley would in February return the favor by traveling to SMU's Dallas campus. The topic was the possible closing of Guantanamo Bay. Major media were there to document the historic completion of SMU's invitation delayed unfairly by prejudice and malaise (Norris 2009). Judges voted for SMU in a policy formatted debate but all observers agreed that all participants-- audience members and debaters were the greater winners for again witnessing the power of debate to bring us together while exploring important differences.

This special issue for *Contemporary Argumentation and Debate* is inspired by the same history that inspired the movie

The Great Debaters in 2007. That history began with the passion of a great coach, Melvin Tolson. Through his pedagogy, student, James Farmer Jr. was stirred and instilled with formative tools that would change the Jim Crow South. Those lessons have been passed down through decades of debate pedagogy and today inspire young students like those coached by Deatherage and Smith. In this issue, some of our nation's young college debate coaches share their insights on how the 21st century will continue the great traditions seen in men like Melvin Tolson and James Farmer Jr. Debate is a timeless pedagogy that can change the world from what it is to what it should be.

References

- Bell, G. (2009). The banquet of my years": James Farmer, Jr., Melvin Tolson and Wiley College, The Marshall Messenger. Retrieved from <http://www.marshallnewsmessenger.com/featr/content/features/greatdebaters/farmer.html?cxtype=rss&cxsvc=7&cxcat=5>.
- Bushong, S. (2009, February 26). Wiley College and Southern Methodist U. debaters face off -- After 74 Years. *Chronicle of Higher Education*.
- Norris, M. (2009, February 26). Wiley College team debates SMU 74 years after meet was canceled. *The Dallas Morning News*.

Ben Voth is Associate Professor of Communication, Director of Forensics, and Chair of Corporate Communication and Public Affairs Division at Southern Methodist University

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Cross Examination Debate Association and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.